Swadeshi on Steroids

Though unfavourable comparisons were often made with Bengal, Tuticorin was fired with the Swadeshi spirit.[65] It was often referred to as 'the Barisal of South India'[66] after the East Bengal town at the forefront of the movement. Swadeshism was very much the zeitgeist. Many events contributed to it and gave a fillip to the movement. The prominent Bengal nationalist Surendranath Banerjea's release from prison, following the Barisal conference, was celebrated in Tuticorin.[67]

In mid-June 1906, Swami Ramakrishnananda of the Ramakrishna Mission arrived in Tuticorin on his way to Colombo to receive Swami Abhedananda who was returning to India from the USA after eleven years. He was received with much fanfare at the railway station and a public meeting was organized on the beach. Taking a leading part in organizing the welcome, VOC himself translated Ramakrishnananda's speech into Tamil. As could be expected, the Swami took the Swadeshi steamer to Colombo. As he boarded the launch, a huge crowd gathered to see him off, and shouts of 'Vande Mataram' rent the air.[68] Two weeks later, on 29 June, he returned with Swami Abhedananda. In his address to the public, Abhedananda spoke on Hinduism, and observed that India's poverty was due to the lack of unity among Indians.[69]

Apart from feverishly working for the shipping company, VOC was also giving public lectures in Tuticorin urging people to avoid purchase of Manchester goods and promote Swadeshi products.[70]

In early August, G. Subramania Iyer, an early champion of economic nationalism, delivered at least two lectures at Tuticorin urging people to buy Swadeshi and boycott foreign goods; he also held forth on the defects of British rule in India. Making a case for democratic mobilization, he asserted that it was the duty of the executive to heed the people's wishes; while Russian (revolutionary) methods need not be followed, unity and concerted action were called for. Lastly, he said that the Swadeshi steamer service should become 'a permanent institution'.[71] While he was not surprised by